



THE ZAHIR PRODUCTIONS

OVERSIGHT

A NEW PLAY BY L.B. DEYO · ELECTRONIC PRESS KIT

LOG LINE

A SECRET HEARING. A CLASSIFIED BREAKTHROUGH. A CRISIS THAT MAY ALREADY BE BEYOND HUMAN CONTROL.

During a secret emergency hearing inside the Dirksen Senate Office Building, government officials, military leaders, and powerful corporate representatives confront a rapidly escalating national security crisis that threatens to reshape the balance of global power.

VENUE

DATES

RUNNING TIME

GENRE

Hyde Park Theatre Austin, Texas	July 30 – August 22, 2026	90 minutes	Political thriller / speculative drama
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REVIEWS

“Sublime construction... powerful and engrossing... *Oversight* is not merely a cautionary tale or an engaging political thriller. It’s a deeper contemplation of the philosophical constructs of cognitive science, morality, and advanced epistemology.”

– [BRIAN PAUL SCIPIONE, CTX LIVE THEATRE](#)

“Philosophical, political, deeply human and unnervingly timely...an ambitious and provocative and well written work that lingers long after the curtain falls.”

– [ELISE KRENTZEL, SUN NEWS AUSTIN](#)

“Ambitious... unsettling... maintains a brisk pace... relevant... fascinating... timely... introduces an extraordinary range of ideas... increasingly urgent... thought-provoking... a steadily escalating political thriller.”

– [SABRINA WALLACE, BROADWAY WORLD AUSTIN](#)

“Inspired writing... subtle brilliance... thoroughly reflects our current conflicted, fraught, violent, mysterious, and confusing social reality... Expectations soared for *Oversight*, and the audiences crowding Hyde Park Theatre have not been disappointed.”

– [DAVID GLEN ROBINSON, CTX LIVE THEATRE](#)

“Tense, bleak, and thrilling, it’s a premium theatrical bottle episode.”

– [CAT MCCARREY, THE AUSTIN CHRONICLE](#)

“LB Deyo’s vigorous, meaty dialogue weaves a plot of intrigue, deception, and a catastrophe... *Oversight* will make you think.”

– MICHAEL MEIGS, CTX LIVE THEATRE

SYNOPSIS

Oversight is a fast-paced political thriller set during a secret emergency session of a special Congressional-Executive committee assembled under false pretenses. The public cover story concerns hypersonic weapons. The real subject is classified at the highest possible level.

As military officials, politicians, intelligence figures, and corporate representatives attempt to assess an emerging

technological threat, the meeting spirals into paranoia, philosophical conflict, political maneuvering, and existential dread.

The deeper the committee digs, the less certain anyone becomes about who is telling the truth, what is really happening beyond the walls of the hearing room, and whether the crisis is already beyond human control.



FULL SYNOPSIS

Oversight unfolds in real time inside Room 106 of the Dirksen Senate Office Building during a closed-door emergency meeting of a special oversight committee. Phones have been confiscated. Secure communications are monitored. A stenographer records every word.

The committee has been assembled under a false public cover concerning hypersonic weapons development. In reality, representatives from the private technology company OpenBrain have requested an emergency briefing regarding a classified breakthrough with potentially catastrophic geopolitical consequences.

Senior OpenBrain scientist Cassandra “Cass” Ogden and Chief Scientist Kareem Najah reveal fragments of a rapidly evolving situation whose implications appear to extend far beyond conventional military or technological competition.

As the hearing progresses, political alliances fracture. Military leaders demand containment. Others argue that hesitation could hand strategic dominance to hostile foreign powers.

What begins as a policy meeting becomes something stranger and more frightening: a confrontation with the limits of political authority, human understanding, and institutional trust.

THE QUESTIONS ON THE TABLE

Can rapidly accelerating technologies remain under meaningful human control?

What happens when governments become dependent upon systems they barely understand?

Is secrecy protecting the public, or merely delaying panic?

How do political institutions respond to threats unlike anything in human history?

THEMES

POWER AND SECRECY

Oversight explores the hidden relationships between governments, corporations, military institutions, and emerging technologies.

HUMAN AGENCY

At its core, *Oversight* asks whether human beings and political institutions can maintain meaningful control during moments of rapid technological and historical acceleration.

TRUTH AND MANIPULATION

The play examines institutional distrust, strategic deception, media fragmentation, and the destabilization of shared reality.

FEAR AND UNCERTAINTY

Like many political thrillers, *Oversight* is deeply concerned with paranoia, uncertainty, competing narratives, and the psychological effects of living inside systems too vast to fully comprehend.

CAST OF CHARACTERS

NINE ROLES · WORLD PREMIERE COMPANY

Erin Johnston

DANU MARA

Chairperson of the special oversight committee.

Cassandra “Cass” Ogden

JESSICA COHEN

Senior OpenBrain scientist.

Kareem Najah

ROMMEL SULIT

Chief Scientist at OpenBrain.

Vice President

JUSTIN SMITH

Representative of the President and the administration.

Secretary of State

LAURA D'ERAMO

A politically experienced and deeply skeptical statesman.

General Stossen

DAVID KROLL

Chairman of the Joint Chiefs of Staff.

Senator Greune

ROBERT PIERSON

A confrontational and skeptical committee member.

Ofelia Cromwell

JANELLE BUCHANAN

The official stenographer recording the proceedings.

Adam Harriman

BRENT WERZNER

CEO of OpenBrain, appearing remotely.



THE COMPANY

THE PLAYWRIGHT

L.B. DEYO

L.B. Deyo is a playwright, novelist, and lecturer based in Austin, Texas. He is the Artistic Director of The Zahir Productions.

Deyo previously wrote and appeared in the paranoid thriller *Apprehension*, which received multiple Austin Theatre Critics Awards nominations and won for Outstanding Original Script.

His work frequently explores paranoia, philosophical conflict, social fragmentation, political anxiety, and the tension between abstract systems and lived human experience.

THE ZAHIR PRODUCTIONS

The Zahir Productions is an Austin-based nonprofit theater company dedicated to creating bold, intellectually ambitious, obsession-worthy theater.

The Zahir seeks to produce work that is theatrically daring, emotionally immediate, philosophically serious, and deeply engaged with the anxieties and contradictions of contemporary life.

MISSION

To create obsession-worthy theater that draws people out of isolation and back into conversation.

PRODUCTION PHOTOS

PHOTOGRAPHS BY BILL MCCULLOUGH · HIGH-RESOLUTION FILES ON REQUEST



ROOM 106



STOSSEN & GREUNE



THE HEARING

PRESS & MEDIA INQUIRIES

L.B. Deyo

Artistic Director

The Zahir Productions

DIRECT

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ONLINE

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OVERSIGHT

HYDE PARK THEATRE · JULY 30 – AUG. 22, 2026

PHOTOGRAPHY BY BILL MCCULLOUGH